Echoes in the Mountain

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COL-600601

ECHOES IN THE MOUNTAIN

White snow covers the distant peaks, and the warming climate has started to reveal the jagged lines of the stone beneath.

However, the weather is still far from pleasant—in fact, the wet early spring has made the grasslands muddy and treacherous.

Still, compared to the other difficulties one might face, bad weather is one of the most harmless.

Meadow, Foothill

Emil: So, what will we have to deal with next?

Emil: Burning cold winds from the other side of the mountain? More troublesome critters? Reckless arcanist refugees? Or maybe an evil trick from Perchta?

Emil grumbles as he wrenches his foot out of the mud. He screams in frustration, smashing his hiking pole against a rock.

Emil: Damn it, I'm sick of this blasted mountain! Captain Semmelweis, we should've never left Vienna!

While their current situation is different from that which they faced in Vienna, it is no less difficult.

Semmelweis: Stop that, Emil. Don't forget, we're still in tatzelwurm territory.

Semmelweis: However, if you want to get sprayed in the face with its stench, I won't stop you.

Semmelweis: "Our brave Emil, in an outstanding contribution to the study of critter biology, used his head to verify the strength of both the teeth and the stench of the tatzelwurm."

Semmelweis' dissuasion apparently does the trick. Emil draws back his head and looks around cautiously.

He is relieved to see that no giant, stinking monsters have emerged from the ground. He takes a few hasty steps to catch up with Semmelweis.

Amused by Emil's comical expression, the other team members let out a burst of good-natured laughter.

Including Emil, they are a small group of six, with Semmelweis leading from the center.

Semmelweis: I'm only joking! We wouldn't just sit around and watch you get ambushed by a monster.

Emil: Thanks for the warning, Captain. I'd hate to end up in a "killed in the line of duty" report at the Belgrade branch.

Emil: I'd at least like to receive the generous severance pay offered by the Field Agent Administration myself, rather than have it distributed to my family upon my death.

After his earlier episode, Emil makes sure to speak softly.

Emil: But really, Captain, how much longer do we need to spend on this blasted mountain?

Semmelweis: Unfortunately, you'll have to survive until we find those Manus followers.

Emil: *sigh* ... Ah, this is killing me. Do we really need to pursue them so closely?

Emil: They're just a bunch of lackeys—they're not even real Manus Vindictae!

Emil: We could've completed three missions in the time we've been tracking them.

Semmelweis: This mission came straight from the top brass at the Field Agent Administration. We had no choice but to accept.

Semmelweis: And besides, although they're just one of many sects, some of these fanatical followers can be more troublesome than a Manus disciple.

Semmelweis: Often times, they're familiar with the norms of the current society, which makes them very good at making problems for us as well as skilled at covering their tracks.

Emil: I still don't get what's so important about these guys that they merit an order from the top brass.

Emil: But if you ask me, if HQ really wants to find these Manus followers, they'd be better off investigating the arcanist refugees.

Semmelweis: Yeah, the riots and murders we've dealt with certainly prove that. It's highly likely that Manus Vindictae is instigating the refugees to do so.

Semmelweis: Most of them are from the Balkans. They came to the Austro-Hungarian Empire after suffering political struggles and enduring the persecution of humans.

Semmelweis: So, it's only natural that the sentiment of "arcanists first" has gained wide acceptance among them.

Semmelweis: Now both the Foundation and the Austro-Hungarian Empire are doing their best to screen these refugees.

Semmelweis: But with so many of them flocking in, and so fast, it's impossible to conduct a thorough screening of every person.

Semmelweis: Besides ... No, never mind.

Emil is too worked up to notice Semmelweis' hesitation.

Emil: Tsk! Manus Vindictae is just riling up these idiots to create chaos for mankind. They clearly have no intention of accepting them!

Emil: Most of these refugees aren't even pure-blood arcanists!

Emil: Even if they tried their whole lives, the vast majority of them would only be able to cast one or two of the simplest, most harmless arcane skills.

Semmelweis: ... Even among arcanists, not everyone can use arcane skills successfully.

Emil: Those who thrive in the hands of the Manus Vindictae are "noble" and "powerful" pure-bloods. As for the trials ... They have no use for mixed-bloods that can't use arcane skills.

Semmelweis: But many refugees have been so brainwashed by propaganda that they're unable to consider whether Manus Vindictae will even fulfill their promise.

Semmelweis: What's even sadder than being exploited is not even getting a reward after the fact.

Upon hearing this, Emil becomes even more indignant. Their walking pace has been gradually speeding up.

Emil: Typical arcanists! Unreasonable! Impatient! Like a swarm of bees that have lost their hive.

Emil: It shames me to think that some of these idiots are from my own nation, Serbia!

Semmelweis: That's why we're tracking the followers. The earlier we clear out these unstable ...

Semmelweis pauses. Emil gives her a puzzled look.

Emil: What is it, Captain?

Semmelweis: Stop.

Semmelweis raises her hand, signaling the team to be on guard.

Emil's expression quickly turns serious.

Semmelweis: Do you smell that? That foul odor?

Emil: It smells like sulfur mixed with wurmsap ... Is it a tatzelwurm?

Emil: I thought they were just a myth.

Semmelweis: Semmelweis smiles to herself.

Semmelweis: I used to think so, too.

Emil: The odor's faint. It's obviously been gone for some time. There are traces on the grass here, too.

Semmelweis: It looks like it went this way.

Emil: Are we going to check it out, Captain?

Semmelweis: Yes. Tatzelwurms don't just appear for no reason. If it's ambushed some travelers, we need to lend a hand.

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COL-600602

Forest, Foothill

Semmelweis: The smell's getting stronger. It must be nearby. Prepare for battle.

The monster's tracks stretch all the way to the back of a small hill. The closer they get, the more distinct the stench becomes.

Upon reaching the other side, the path before them opens up.

Camp, Foothill

A messy campsite with half-pitched tents, splintered trees, and scattered wood all indicate that this place recently experienced a major battle.

But most notable of all is what looks like a monster's tail lying in the center.

Team Member I: Ugh ... What is this? It's disgusting.

Semmelweis flips open her notebook to compare the severed part to her records.

Semmelweis: Indeed, this is a tatzelwurm tail.

Semmelweis: It looks like they successfully fended it off.

Team Member I: But ... They seem to have retreated in a hurry. Perhaps they feared another ambush?

Semmelweis: Wait, don't move.

Semmelweis' expression turns serious as she notices a thin black liquid trickling from a splintered tree. She reaches out her finger, catching a few drops.

Emil: Is that ... black pus from a Manus follower?!

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: So, a tatzelwurm attacked the followers we've been tracking. This must've been the camp.

Emil: Shoot! We were so close to catching those thugs!

Semmelweis: Emil, search the campsite with me.

Semmelweis: The rest of you secure the area. Both the tatzelwurm and Manus followers may come back. Keep your guard up.

All: Yes, Captain!

Semmelweis makes her way to the tent in the center of the camp. She half-crouches in front of the campfire, holding out her palms.

Semmelweis: The fire's still warm. They left the campground about two hours ago.

Semmelweis: Based on the aftermath, it seems the tatzelwurm's target was this tent in the center of the camp.

Semmelweis: Is this ... where the leader of Perchta was staying?

Despite sharing the same name as the legendary arcane supernaturalist in the German region, Perchta is unmistakably a reinvented branch of the sect.

This is the Manus sect that the field agent squad is currently tracking.

While talking with Emil, Semmelweis conceals a crucial piece of information.

Perchta is not a regular offshoot of Manus Vindictae, but a dangerous organization that has been linked to over thirty murders.

Semmelweis: No. It's not so much that this is the central tent. Rather, it's been placed where everyone can keep watch over it.

Semmelweis: Somewhere everyone can see ... Could it be ...?

Semmelweis dips her head and makes her way into the tent.

The inside is empty, save for the flash of a shiny object in the corner, which catches her eye.

Semmelweis: What's this?

Semmelweis: A ... mirror?

She examines the mirror. Some sort of misty veil is obfuscating the reflection. It's impossible to see its image.

This was clearly created using arcane skills.

Semmelweis flips the mirror over. The back is engraved with an illumination incantation.

Semmelweis: Imago Imprint!

Semmelweis recites the incantation.

The mirror remains hazy. It has coldly rejected her poor excuse for an incantation.

It was worth a shot.

She smiles and puts the mirror away.

As she does so, she doesn't notice the strange light that flashes across the mirror's surface.

At that very moment, Semmelweis' communication device buzzes.

Semmelweis: Madam Lindsay, how can I help you?

Madam Lindsay.: You're a little slow in answering your comm. Did something happen?

Semmelweis: ... No, nothing.

Semmelweis' superior does not dwell much on the issue. She quickly moves on.

Madam Lindsay.: How is the Perchta investigation going?

Semmelweis: You read my mind. I was just about to report to you.

Semmelweis: ... That's all. Do you have any questions, Madam Lindsay?

Madam Lindsay.: Using tatzelwurms to track down Perchta ... Your ingenuity has exceeded my expectations. Good work.

Semmelweis: I'm flattered, but the only reason I could do it is because you instructed me on the habits of tatzelwurms.

Semmelweis: “Tatzelwurms do not have eyes; they hunt by relying on arcane skill fluctuations to locate their prey on the surface.”

Semmelweis: A team almost entirely composed of humans versus a team entirely composed of arcanists—without a doubt, tatzelwurms would be more inclined to attack the latter.

Semmelweis: But ... I still want to ask you a question about this.

Madam Lindsay.: Hurry up and ask. My time is valuable.

Semmelweis: Here's the thing. The tatzelwurm attacked the tent in the very center of the camp.

Madam Lindsay.: ... Hmph. Haven't you figured it out yet?

Madam Lindsay.: Located in the center of the camp, with no cover around it, in full view of everyone —

Madam Lindsay.: It’s quite simple. That's the tent where they housed the prisoner.

Semmelweis: Where they housed the prisoner ... I see. The tatzelwurm went for the easiest target.

Madam Lindsay.: She's very important to the Manus followers. Perchta will protect her at all costs.

Semmelweis: So the tatzelwurm attacked the last person it should have messed with ...

Semmelweis: Madam Lindsay, it sounds like you have an idea as to the identity of the prisoner. Is there anything I should know?

Madam Lindsay.: No, there's no information I need to disclose to you.

Semmelweis: That was a little harsh, Madam Lindsay. I thought we were friends!

Madam Lindsay.: Back to work, Semmelweis.

She promptly ends the communication.

Semmelweis: What a pity. I didn't get to thank her for answering my questions.

As if echoing Semmelweis’ words, a faint female voice emanates from the communication device.

If she had not been listening carefully, it would have been easily missed.

Semmelweis: Huh? Is there someone else on the comm? Hello?

Semmelweis: Sorry, your voice is a bit soft. I didn’t catch what you said.

Semmelweis strains to make out the voice.

Soon, it dawns on her.

Semmelweis: Is someone singing?

The voice is not coming from the comm, but drifting over from the other side of the foothills ...

... like the gentle sound of wind brushing over the desert sands or the reverberation of the final chord of a sacred organ performance.

Semmelweis sets down the communication device. She furrows her brow as she tries to discern the source of the singing.

Semmelweis: ...

The song seems to possess a different kind of magic, one that entices you to explore it further.

Semmelweis: How odd ... What is that song?

Compelled to follow its sound, Semmelweis starts walking in its direction.

One, two, three steps—even if an abyss opened up in front of her, she would not stop.

Emil: Captain, we've got a problem!

Emil's voice cuts through the song, adding a discordant note to that entrancing melody. She snaps back to reality.

Semmelweis: ...!

Semmelweis: Am I hearing things ...?

Semmelweis: She shakes her head as if to shake the song out of her mind.

Semmelweis: But the song still lingers in her ears.

Semmelweis: Semmelweis takes a deep breath, pushes her doubts to the back of her mind, and looks back at Emil.

Semmelweis: What happened?

Emil: A member of the patrol team relayed a message. They've spotted a group of critters nearby.

Semmelweis: The stench of the tatzelwurm must have attracted them.

Semmelweis: That's unfortunate. Our investigation isn't over yet. We can't let them destroy the scene.

Semmelweis: Gather the team and prepare for battle.

Emil: Roger! I'll notify the others right away.

Semmelweis: ... Hold on.

Emil: Is there something else, Captain?

Semmelweis closes her eyes.

Semmelweis: Did you hear ...

Semmelweis: Someone singing?

Emil: Someone singing ...?

Emil listens intently.

There is no sound but the mournful trombone of the wind blowing over the mountains.

Emil: No, I don't hear anything.

Emil: Captain ... Did you find something?

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: No, nothing. Maybe I heard wrong.

Semmelweis turns her head to face the song.

The snow-covered mountaintops reflect the sunlight, emanating a brilliant white glow.

Semmelweis: Have my hallucinations really become this real ...?

Semmelweis: Looks like the condition is worse than I thought.

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COL-600603

Laplace Rehabilitation Center

Doctor: I'm very sorry, but your condition ...

The doctor before her appears troubled.

Semmelweis: A familiar opening line, Doctor.

Semmelweis: I know what will happen next. So go ahead. Give me the bad news.

Semmelweis: It's fine. I'm prepared for what you have to say.

Doctor: This condition is ... extremely rare.

Doctor: The majority of the records related to this condition were lost in the "Storm". Even the recovery centers won't be able to find a cure for quite some time.

Semmelweis: I see.

Semmelweis: Thank you for your honesty, Doctor.

Semmelweis: But I still have a question.

Semmelweis: How much longer do I get to live?

The doctor falls silent as he considers her question.

Doctor: Around three to six months. During this time, the condition will affect both your body and mind.

Semmelweis: So, I still have three months to live. Sounds good.

Doctor: But I can't promise that the condition won't worsen sooner than that.

Doctor: Therefore, the Foundation has temporarily suspended your position as an investigator and has arranged for you to rest at a recovery center. That way, the medical department can keep you under observation.

Doctor: During that time, the recovery center will carry out consultations to try and find a treatment for you.

Semmelweis: I appreciate your kindness, but I'll just take it slow while I continue working on missions.

Doctor: Don't be a hero. You're not fit to continue as an investigator.

Doctor: Rest and a speedy recovery are the best options.

Semmelweis: You're right. I'm not fit to keep working as an investigator.

Semmelweis: But ... what if I were to join the Field Agent Administration?

Doctor: You mean the "History Maintenance Team"?

Doctor: Miss Semmelweis, as an investigator, there's no need for you to take on such a dangerous position!

The doctor has nearly leapt to his feet in surprise. This choice would be confusing to anyone.

Semmelweis: That may be true ... But I know the nature of field agent work better than you do. It's the best place for me right now.

Semmelweis: You and I both know this condition is incurable.

Semmelweis: Instead of spending the next three months pointlessly waiting around, I'd like to use my remaining time to contribute to the Foundation.

Doctor: The nature of the field agent teams is fundamentally different from that of investigators.

Doctor: I hope you aren't making such a big decision on a whim.

Semmelweis: So it's a little more dangerous and has a higher mortality rate ...

Semmelweis: What difference does that make to someone who has less than half a year to live?

Semmelweis: I have a lot to be grateful to the Foundation for.

Semmelweis: Unlike other arcanists, my bloodline gives me no advantage.

Semmelweis: But the Foundation still chose me to serve as an investigator.

Semmelweis: I hope, through this, I can repay the Foundation's faith in me.

Silence.

For some time, neither Semmelweis nor the doctor break it.

The light is beginning to fall. A faint shadow outlines the doctor's body.

Doctor: ... I understand. Your feelings for the Foundation are admirable.

Doctor: —Is that what you thought I was going to say?

The doctor erupts into a harsh laugh, his tone dripping with sarcasm.

Doctor: You arcanists like to think you're so smart, but then you wind up shooting yourselves in the foot.

Doctor: Oh, I forgot. You're not even an arcanist.

Doctor: I mean, can an arcanist who can't use arcane skills really be called an arcanist?

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: I don't know what you're talking about, Doctor.

Semmelweis: It's an honor to contribute to the Foundation.

The doctor's face twists unnaturally.

Doctor: Neither the Foundation nor Manus Vindictae care about a "rotten wand" who can't use arcane skills.

Semmelweis: "Rotten Wand" ... I've rarely heard that term since becoming an investigator.

Semmelweis: What a nostalgic expression.

Doctor: Ha, you may not have the arcane skills, but you certainly have the inherent stupidity of an arcanist.

Doctor: Your unique talent lies in always making the wrong decision.

Doctor: Perhaps you think this is resistance, but you're only struggling in vain.

Doctor: Just like how the fig wasp will eventually return to the dark, cramped fig!

Doctor: Wherever you flee, the filthy, cold corner that is your destiny is waiting for you, you useless little arcanist.

Doctor: It is your fate—an irreversible fate.

Semmelweis' expression remains unchanged, as if the doctor were talking about someone else.

She stands up and bows to him.

Semmelweis: Time's up. I must be going. Please excuse me, Doctor.

In a flash, the doctor regains his composure.

He pushes his glasses up and once again takes his seat behind the desk.

Doctor: When did you realize this was a hallucination?

Semmelweis: From the start.

Semmelweis: You should know that I never dwell on the past.

Doctor: Yes ... But we shall meet again one day, Semmelweis.

???: ... Cap—

Semmelweis: I was prepared for this.

???: ... Cap—Captain!

Meadow, Foothill

Emil: Captain!

The visions before her melt away, and the unmistakable sound of the song rings anew in her ears.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: I'm fine, Emil.

Emil: Thank goodness! You finally responded!

Semmelweis: What happened just now?

Emil: Just after the battle ended, you suddenly froze in place. You weren't responding to anything!

Semmelweis: ...

The hallucinations are becoming more frequent and increasingly realistic. It's almost impossible to distinguish illusion from reality.

And it is not just hallucinations; even her own memory is failing her.

No matter how hard Semmelweis tries, she can't remember the recent battle.

This is not a good sign, but it is not unexpected.

Semmelweis: I was just a little absent-minded. Don't worry about me.

Emil: Really? You better be okay. If something happens to you, I'll have no hope of getting a promotion—

Emil cuts himself off mid-sentence, realizing his misstep. He lets out an embarrassed chuckle.

Emil: Ahaha ... Of course, your health is important too, Captain ...

Semmelweis: Don't worry, my mind was just wandering. That's all.

Semmelweis: Attention everyone! Clear up the battlefield and get back to searching for evidence. We must determine the whereabouts of the Manus Vindictae.

Emil: Yes, Captain!

Semmelweis looks off into the distance. The sky is turning orange as the sun dips behind the snowy mountain peaks. She lets out a small laugh.

Semmelweis: I see. So this is what you meant by "affecting both body and mind".

Semmelweis: What a shame.

Semmelweis: But no number of illusions will shake my determination.

Semmelweis turns to leave.

The glow of the sunset spills over her, casting a long shadow.

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[English text unavailable]

COL-600604

Forest, Foothill

Madam Lindsay.: Progress report, Semmelweis.

Semmelweis: All's well, Madam Lindsay. We've confirmed the direction of Perchta's retreat.

Madam Lindsay remains silent, prompting Semmelweis to explain further.

Semmelweis: They took the captive to an abandoned village nearby, apparently in an attempt to hide them.

Semmelweis: For an extremist organization associated with numerous murders, their actions seem inconsistent with their past conduct.

Semmelweis: Clearly, they're trying to gain something crucial from their abductee. Something significant enough to make them forgo their usual methods.

Madam Lindsay.: So, what's your assessment?

Semmelweis: I have a not-yet-fully-formed speculation.

Madam Lindsay.: Do tell.

Semmelweis: I think the prisoner is related to the arcanist refugees.

Madam Lindsay.: What's your reasoning?

Semmelweis: Based on our investigation in Vienna, and that of other field agent teams, we can infer Manus Vindictae's current goals.

Semmelweis: They're trying to incite the arcanist refugees to create chaos for the human authorities.

Semmelweis: Whether they riot or go on a murderous spree, these desperate refugee communities are prime recruits for Manus Vindictae.

Semmelweis: However, under the dual control of the Foundation and the Austro-Hungarian Empire, Manus Vindictae's incitement remains relatively limited in scale.

Semmelweis: They aren't satisfied with that. So, they're attempting to find a way to penetrate the refugee community more quickly ...

Semmelweis: ... by working with the refugee leaders. Or by killing them.

Madam Lindsay.: In other words, you think the captive is a leader of the arcanist refugee community.

Semmelweis: The fact that such a large number of arcanist refugees were able to travel from the Balkans to Vienna suggests that they were organized.

Semmelweis: Considering that Perchta tends to prefer house arrest ...

Semmelweis: The most reasonable analysis is that the prisoner holds a special position in the refugee community, one that even the Manus Vindictae cannot simply replace.

Semmelweis: These refugees are not a homogeneous group; there are factions inclined towards the Manus and those who prefer to keep their distance.

Semmelweis: This may be the epitome of the struggle between the two factions.

Madam Lindsay.: Your inference is logical and fits with the intel the Foundation previously obtained.

Madam Lindsay.: In that case, complete the mission quickly and find out what they're up to.

Semmelweis: On it.

Madam Lindsay.: After you return to the Foundation, the recovery center will propose a new treatment plan.

Madam Lindsay.: They've gathered some information on your condition.

Semmelweis: Thank you, Madam Lindsay.

Madam Lindsay.: I had nothing to do with it. You can thank the contributions of our colleagues in the recovery center.

Madam Lindsay.: Also, I have a message for you.

Madam Lindsay.: The LSCC just reached a conclusion.

Madam Lindsay.: The critical point of the era will manifest in Vienna.

Semmelweis: ...!

Madam Lindsay.: As a “former” investigator, I believe you understand what this means.

For a moment, every muscle in Semmelweis' body tenses.

She regains control of her body, and her expression grows serious.

Semmelweis: I need to share this intel with Hofmann.

Madam Lindsay.: Naturally.

Semmelweis: Manus Vindictae's research on the critical point has been ahead of us from the start. They must have this information too.

Semmelweis: My apologies, Madam Lindsay. I must hurry. Who knows what extreme measures the followers might take under these circumstances?

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COL-600605

Abandoned Village

After a short rest, the team disperses into the abandoned village. The Manus followers have retreated quickly, as if they anticipated the current scene.

Semmelweis: That's odd.

How long ago had the singing stopped?

When the long-lost silence descended again, it somehow felt a little ... out of place.

Semmelweis: Did it disappear during the battle just now?

Perhaps, for only then could it have disappeared without her noticing.

The return of Emil interrupts Semmelweis’ pondering.

Emil: Captain!

Semmelweis: Did you find anything?

Emil: Following your indications, we found a secret chamber nearby.

Emil: The chamber bears traces of a traveler's brief stay. It's clear that the Manus Vindictae were there.

Semmelweis: Take me there.

Emil: Based on the traces of arcane skills, we believe they were rescued in the chaos of the battle just now.

Semmelweis: Hmm ... Are there others who are trying to rescue the prisoner too?

Semmelweis: I see ... The refugees used us.

Despite this realization, Semmelweis' face shows no sign of discontent.

The room is modest, with only a small window connecting it to the outside world.

It is simply decorated, with few noteworthy features.

Semmelweis notices an envelope on the desk.

Semmelweis: Is this ... a letter?

Semmelweis: Did the Manus Vindictae leave it for me? Or perhaps it was ...

Semmelweis: ... the prisoner.

The answer to this question is not hard to find; all she has to do is open the letter.

Semmelweis reaches out and picks up the letter from the table.

The ink has not yet dried. Clearly, the sender left not long ago.

Semmelweis: ...!

The letter is not long—just a few lines.

However, Semmelweis reads it several times, searching for any hint of the Manus Vindictae's whereabouts.

Semmelweis: Is this ... some sort of hallucination?

Semmelweis: —No, it can't be.

If this was indeed a hallucination, it was so realistic as to be indiscernible from reality.

Semmelweis takes a deep breath and calms herself. She doesn't want Emil to notice her heightened state.

She examines the letter again, word by word.

"Hello, unknown visitor."

"I know a way to cure your condition and keep you alive."

"That's right, I have a method to help you survive the affliction given to you by the infected."

"Please find me in Vienna. Then, you will find redemption and overcome impurity."

There is a signature at the bottom.

Semmelweis: Lorelei from the Rhine.

Who is this person? How does she know all this?

Semmelweis' biggest secret is written so plainly, like an open menu awaiting the scrutiny of a customer.

Countless questions begin to swirl in her mind.

For a scholar, "the infected" is too broad a term. It encompasses countless failures and few survivors.

Therefore, in arcanum, there is a more precise and direct way to refer to this disease that almost exclusively affects arcanists.

The Beyond Disease.

That is the true name of Semmelweis' affliction.

Emil: Captain, what's wrong? You've been staring at that letter for a while ...

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: This letter contains certain classified information that I intend to pass on to the Foundation.

Semmelweis calmly removes her comm from its case and calls Madam Lindsay.

Seeing this, Emil asks no more questions. He leaves the room.

Madam Lindsay.: Semmelweis, what's the status on the mission?

Semmelweis: Everything went smoothly, Madam Lindsay. I was just about to report the details. We—

Madam Lindsay.: No, the debriefing can be postponed.

Madam Lindsay.: There's now an urgent mission of even greater importance.

Madam Lindsay.: Investigator Hofmann in Vienna has requested the assistance of the Field Agent Administration.

Madam Lindsay.: Unfortunately, the other squads are unable to reach Vienna in the required time.

Semmelweis: Vienna...

“Please find me in Vienna. Then, you will find redemption and overcome impurity.”

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: I understand. I have two “Teleport” arcane skill floppy disks. They'll help me reach Vienna quickly.

Madam Lindsay.: I promise you, this is your last mission in this era.

Madam Lindsay.: When you return, the medical department will talk to you again about your condition.

Semmelweis: Madam Lindsay, Hofmann is my friend, too. I'm glad for the opportunity to help her.

Upon ending the communication, Semmelweis places the communication device back into her backpack, just as she had done countless times before.

Semmelweis: “Lorelei from the Rhine” ...

—Semmelweis mutters, looking towards Vienna.

Semmelweis: Is this also fate's doing?

THE END

[English text unavailable]

COL-600606

Laplace Rehabilitation Center

A familiar location.

Doctor: We meet again.

The doctor pushes up his glasses and smiles kindly.

Doctor: You still haven’t given up?

Doctor: You should know that your struggle is meaningless.

Doctor: Neither the Foundation nor those witch doctor arcanists can do anything about your condition.

Doctor: Even before the "Storm", the Foundation had few options for dealing with this condition.

Doctor: They have even fewer now.

Semmelweis: ...

Doctor: Perhaps you'd like me to recount the data?

Semmelweis: I know perfectly well what's happening now.

Semmelweis: Arcanists infected with the Beyond Disease will face a physical and mental breakdown.

Semmelweis: The hallucinations and pain will destroy them from the inside out. Less than 5% of arcanists survive the process.

Semmelweis: Those arcanists who are lucky enough to make it through to the other side are called "the infected".

Semmelweis: The majority of them will be plagued by mental illness for the rest of their lives.

Semmelweis: Did I miss anything?

Doctor: You seem to know what's going on, "Rotten Wand".

Doctor: You should be grateful for your little bit of arcanist blood.

Doctor: It's given you that 5% chance that you wouldn't have if you were human.

Doctor: But, should you really be grateful?

Doctor: You're like an ignorant hunter who greedily pursues the white stag, charging headlong into a swamp.

Doctor: Isn't it better to hurry back to the Foundation and accept your final moments?

Semmelweis: The Foundation will help me. I've never questioned that.

Semmelweis: Which is also why I can't sit and wait for death there.

Semmelweis: I'll use my remaining time to contribute to the Foundation and pay them back for all they've done for me.

Doctor: It seems you're more inclined to die in the "Storm" like a stray dog than to enjoy your last moments in peace.

Doctor: You're in over your head, trying to fight destiny. Little do you know, your actions are just a line in the footnote of fate.

Semmelweis: ... Perhaps my mind has become deranged as a result of the infection; maybe I've snapped—

Semmelweis: But you cannot shake my determination. After all, you're just a hallucination.

Doctor: A hallucination? No. You'll understand soon. It's not that simple.

Doctor: You were never special, Semmelweis.

Doctor: You're just an ordinary person who can't even use arcane skills.

Doctor: What makes you think you're special? What makes you think you can defeat destiny?

Doctor: —You'll simply disappear into history. Just like the scum who don't survive to be called "infected".

Semmelweis: ...

Doctor: Alright, you can go. Today's treatment is finished.

The scene shifts. By the time Semmelweis comes to her senses, she has left the hallucination.

Semmelweis: ... He was boring.

She lowers her head to examine her hands.

They're beginning to fade away, becoming transparent. She can see the light shining through her palms and hitting the ground beneath.

Intense pain tears at the gaps between bone and flesh, as if the two are trying to rend themselves from one another.

Semmelweis: The breakdown of my mind and body is accelerating.

Semmelweis: Is it because of the singing ...?

Since the singing started, the symptoms of the Beyond Disease have rapidly increased in intensity.

Emil: Captain, are you ... Are you okay?

Emil looks worried.

Emil: Does the letter say anything special?

Emil: Since you first looked at it, you've been in a daze—oh, I mean, thinking.

Semmelweis looks down at the letter in her hand.

"Hello, unknown visitor."

"I know a way to cure your condition and keep you alive."

"That's right, I have a method to help you survive the affliction given to you by the infected."

"Please find me in Vienna. Then, you will find redemption and overcome impurity."

Lorelei from the Rhine.

After looking at the letter for a while, Semmelweis smiles.

She grasps the paper on both sides ...

... and tears it in half.

Emil: Captain?!

Fold, tear. Fold, tear. Fold, tear.

She continues until the letter is nothing but an unreadable pile of scraps.

Semmelweis: Emil.

Emil: ... C-Captain?

Emil looks baffled. It isn't like Semmelweis to behave so irrationally.

Semmelweis: I don't care about your betrayal, Emil.

Emil: W-what do you mean, Captain? I don't understand.

Semmelweis: As a field agent team captain, being prepared for betrayal from within is a must. I saw this coming.

Emil: W-wait, Captain, are you joking? Was the rumor actually true?

Semmelweis: Don't worry, I don't intend on using "that method". There's no need to go that far.

Semmelweis: Evidence indicates that the prisoner, "Lorelei from the Rhine", left during the battle with the Manus Vindictae.

Semmelweis: In order for her to leave so smoothly, someone must have helped her.

Semmelweis: And for someone to pull off this operation with such precision and leave a letter, they obviously knew where we were.

Emil: Wait, Captain, surely you don't suspect me, do you?! Do you really think I'm passing information to "Lorelei from the Rhine"?

Emil: Captain, I-I'm completely loyal to the Foundation. How could I do something like that?

Semmelweis ignores him, her words calmly cutting through his wailing.

Semmelweis: Therefore, when I saw this letter, I came to a conclusion.

Semmelweis: There must be a spy on the team. One who is feeding information to the enemy.

Semmelweis: And most of the refugees we're tracking are from your home country—Serbia.

Emil: I, I ...

Emil: Please believe me, Captain! I have no ill intent towards you! I just, I just—!

Semmelweis: Though uncommon, this isn't unheard of in the Field Agent Association.

Emil: Argh, I never should have helped them in the first place! This confounded letter ... Damn arcanists! Unreliable little—

Semmelweis: So, are you one of these refugee rescuers?

Emil: No, no, no! I'm not! I'm a human for crying out loud! How could I have anything to do with those arcanists?

Emil: I just ... Just happened to assist them!

Emil: I tipped them off, told them we were going to take care of this team of Manus followers, and that was it!

Emil: I had no idea what they were up to!

Semmelweis: Why did you do it? As you said, you're a human and have no reason to help them.

Emil is silent for a moment. Then he heaves a sigh.

Emil: Along the way, I was thinking about what you said earlier.

Emil: You said that neither the Foundation nor the Austro-Hungarian Empire could quickly eliminate the influence of Manus Vindictae on the refugees.

Emil: Do you know what that means?

Emil: It means the Austro-Hungarian Empire has to deal with the problems posed by the refugees as quickly as possible.

Semmelweis: The Empire is well aware of the damage a group of unstable arcanists can do.

Semmelweis: So, when the arcanist refugees can't be controlled, the Empire isn't averse to taking extreme measures.

Emil: Just like they did in the past.

Emil: After all, they bear no moral responsibility for them.

Semmelweis: Yep. It's a common practice these days.

Emil: They're my countrymen. I can't sit back and watch a tragedy like this unfold. I have to find a way to stop it.

Emil: Believe me, I have no sympathy for arcanists. They're to blame for all of this.

Emil: But even so, they shouldn't suffer such a fate.

Emil: Even if they are Manus scum, they should be judged and punished by the law. Their fates shouldn't be determined by the whims of old men!

Emil spits on the ground, venting his discontent.

Emil: I don't know who "Lorelei from the Rhine" really is. But what I do know is that she can stop the refugees from turning to Manus Vindictae.

Emil: And that's enough.

Emil: All this careful exploration and tolerance ... It's not making any difference! It's time to do something.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: I understand your motivations.

Semmelweis: I must say, your behavior surprises me a bit, Emil.

Semmelweis: I thought you really hated arcanists.

Emil: Everyone hates arcanists. But they're still people—people who live side by side in this world with me!

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: There's something I neglected to tell you. I'm also an arcanist.

Emil raises his head in disbelief.

Emil: Impossible. Why would the Foundation send an arcanist to ...?

Emil trails off, quickly realizing something much more important.

Emil: Hang on! Captain, what I mean to say is ... Uh, arcanists are good people, too ...

Semmelweis can't help but laugh.

Semmelweis: Look at me, Emil.

Emil: Captain?

Semmelweis: I'm not going to punish you.

Semmelweis: While you have taken advantage of our organization, investigating Manus Vindictae falls within our scope of work.

Semmelweis: Besides, this is rather important intelligence.

Semmelweis: So, I'll hide what you've done from the higher-ups.

Emil: C-captain—A-are you serious?

Semmelweis: Reporting your actions would serve no purpose. It would only cost me a team member.

Emil: T-thank you so much, Captain! I-I ...

Semmelweis' communication device buzzes.

Semmelweis: Good timing. It's a dispatch from the higher-ups.

Semmelweis: If you're worried, you can listen in on the call.

Emil: N-no, I trust you, Captain!

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis is not lying. She does not intend to report Emil's actions to Madam Lindsay.

To her, it makes no sense.

Semmelweis: Everything went smoothly, Madam Lindsay. I was just about to report the details. We—

The critical point of the era has emerged, which means the arrival of the "Storm" is imminent.

Upon its arrival, the "Storm" will wipe out his existence completely.

There is no need for her to do anything.

Semmelweis: You mean Vienna?

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: I understand. I have two “Teleport” arcane skill floppy disks. They'll help me reach Vienna quickly.

Semmelweis: Madam Lindsay, Hofmann is my friend, too. I'm glad for the opportunity to help her.

Upon ending the communication, Semmelweis places the communication device back into her backpack, just as she had done countless times before.

Semmelweis: “Lorelei from the Rhine”?

—Semmelweis mutters, looking towards Vienna.

Semmelweis: Perhaps ... It’s destiny.

THE END